Andreeva Wins 11 Games in a Row to Stun Sabalenka

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Mirra Andreeva was losing. Then everything changed.

The 19-year-old Russian was 4-1 down in the first set against Aryna Sabalenka, the world number two, at the WTA Finals. Then Andreeva found her **rhythm** and never gave it back. She won 11 games in a row on her way to a 6-4, 6-0 victory that sent her into the last four.

Andreeva, the French Open champion, mixed loopy high balls that wrong-footed Sabalenka with easy power from the back of the court. She hit 16 **winners** and made only six **unforced errors**, carving out sharp angles that left Sabalenka scrambling. The only wobble came when she served for the first set at 15-30 down she answered with three **aces** in a row.

Sabalenka, a four-time major singles winner, started strongly and held a double-break lead. But from there she won only 10 more points in the whole match. Her shots grew wilder, and she finished with 23 **unforced errors**. Tape on her knee did not seem to slow her down.

Andreeva was honest about it afterwards. 'I feel like Aryna did not have the best day,' she told Sky Sports. 'I feel like I cannot really take all the credit today. I'm just happy. I had a goal in front of me to commit no matter what and control the things I can control.'

The result means Andreeva goes through as the group winner. Sabalenka still has a chance: the winner of her final group match on Friday against Elina Svitolina will join Andreeva in the semi-finals.

Svitolina kept her own hopes alive with a comeback win over Karolina Muchova. She took a **medical timeout** for a right hip injury after losing the first set. But she fought back, helped by Muchova's 39 **unforced errors**, to stay in the hunt.

Word Treasure

rhythm -- The steady flow of good play that helps a player keep winning points.

winners -- Shots that win the point because the other player cannot reach them.

unforced errors -- Mistakes a player makes on their own, without being forced by a great shot.

aces -- Serves so good that the other player cannot touch the ball.

medical timeout -- A short break in a match so a player can get treatment for an injury.

Background you need

The WTA Finals is a big tennis event where the best players of the season play each other in groups, and the group winners move on to the semi-finals.

In tennis, a match is split into sets, and a player wins a set by winning enough games, so winning games in a row can quickly turn a match around.

Top players use different kinds of shots, like high looping balls and sharp angles, to move their opponent around the court and force mistakes.

Players sometimes take a medical timeout when they are hurt, so they can get treatment and keep playing.

Break it down

LEAD: Mirra Andreeva came back from 4-1 down to beat Aryna Sabalenka 6-4, 6-0 at the WTA Finals and reach the last four.

KEY EVENT: Andreeva won 11 games in a row after finding her rhythm.

+- WHO: Mirra Andreeva, the 19-year-old Russian and French Open champion, against Aryna Sabalenka, the world number two.

+- HOW: Andreeva mixed loopy high balls with power, hit 16 winners, and made only six unforced errors.

+- WHEN: Sabalenka led 4-1 in the first set, then Andreeva took over; Sabalenka's last group match is on Friday.

EVIDENCE: Sabalenka won only 10 more points after her double-break lead and finished with 23 unforced errors.

OPEN QUESTION: Will Sabalenka beat Elina Svitolina on Friday to join Andreeva in the semi-finals?

SIDE STORY: Elina Svitolina fought back to beat Karolina Muchova after a medical timeout for a right hip injury.

Why it matters

Big comebacks show that a match is never over until the last point, and they remind young players to keep fighting and control what they can control, just as Andreeva did.

Test what you remember

1. How many games in a row did Andreeva win?

(A) 9 games
(B) 10 games
(C) 12 games
(D) 11 games

2. What was the final score of the match?

(A) 7-5, 6-2
(B) 6-4, 6-0
(C) 6-0, 6-4
(D) 6-3, 6-3

3. How many unforced errors did Sabalenka finish with?

(A) 16
(B) 10
(C) 23
(D) 39

4. What did Andreeva do when she served for the first set at 15-30 down?

(A) She hit three aces in a row
(B) She took a medical timeout
(C) She asked for a new racket
(D) She lost the set

5. Who will Sabalenka play in her final group match?

(A) Mirra Andreeva
(B) Karolina Muchova
(C) Elina Svitolina
(D) Aryna Sabalenka

6. How many unforced errors did Muchova make in her match against Svitolina?

(A) 23
(B) 39
(C) 16
(D) 10

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Mirra Andreeva: She said Sabalenka did not have her best day and that she could not take all the credit.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):